



Apple Music for India: First Look

Apple Music has finally been introduced with the iOS 8.4 updates for Apple devices and PCs. Does India finally get a world-class music service?

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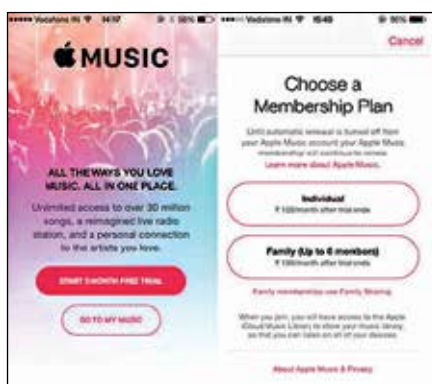
Apple Music has been endlessly spoken about and discussed, ever since rumours sparked off by Apple's acquisition of Beats. Apple Music has finally been launched across 100 nations. The initial offering from Apple Music is a three-month trial duration, in which users can access all features of the music streaming service. Post-trial, you can continue using Apple Music on a subscription model.

Meanwhile, India has seen a growing number of music streaming services enter the country. Apps like Saavn and Gaana provide free ad-based streaming, along with a subscription model which allows users to access music offline. With increasing demand for curated playlists and unending music libraries, we take a look into Apple Music to find how well it fares when it comes to Indian music.

Setup and payment procedure

After updating to iOS 8.4, the biggest notable difference is the Music app. The theme of the icon has changed and opening it leads directly to the Apple Music welcome screen. Your three-month trial begins here, wherein the first step involves choosing a subscription plan for post-trial usage. Thereafter, you are required to sign in through your Apple ID and enter your card details.

It is here that Apple has made it slightly confusing. To begin your three-month trial, you will have to select either of the two subscription plans: the Individual plan for Rs. 120 per month or the Family plan for Rs. 190 per month. Although, the first three months are free, choosing a subscription



Setting up payment procedure

scheme for the future has been made mandatory by Apple and auto-pay is enabled by default. However, you can deactivate auto-pay once you log in and setup Apple Music. All you need to do is access your profile settings, view your Apple ID and verify your payment status under 'Subscription'.

Moreover, Apple charges Rs. 60 for iTunes registration to those setting up an Apple ID for the first time. The company also requires a Credit Card on file to set up your Apple Music account. That means, you will not be able to start the free trial unless you provide valid credit card details.



Selecting music preferences

Selecting music preferences

Apple Music has five tabs: For You, New, Radio, Connect, and My Music. You will be prompted to choose your favourite genres, which appear as floating red bubbles. Indian music on Apple Music includes genres such as Bollywood, Indian Pop, Indian Classical Fusion, Indian Classical, Ghazals, and Sufi. The regional music categories available rivals those offered by Saavn, which is impressive.

Choosing your favourite artists among the genres is simple is a simple process involving a few taps. Apple Music shows up a number of Indian musicians, including bands and music ventures such as Advaita, Tabla Beat Science, Raghu Dixit, and Paradigm Shift, along with Indian singers from the classic era such Kishore Kumar and Ghulam Ali. Once you're done selecting, tap on 'Done', and a curated feed will open on the 'For You' tab. The list has tiled windows, displaying a cover image and a brief on each playlist. Tap on one to see the playlist.

Automated playlists feed

Apart from curated playlists, you get artist-specific and album-specific playlists. In our curated feed, we got a 22-track A-list of Bollywood, a 16-track Best of Indian Pop.

You can search for artists of your choice from the search button on the top-right of the screen, that appears on each tab. To check how good it is at finding Indian artists, we searched for Nucleya, Mohammed Rafi, Parikrama, Neha Kakkar among others. Each of these artists returned relevant results.

All that's trending, and mood-curated playlists

Moving to the New tab, it features a dropdown list from which you can